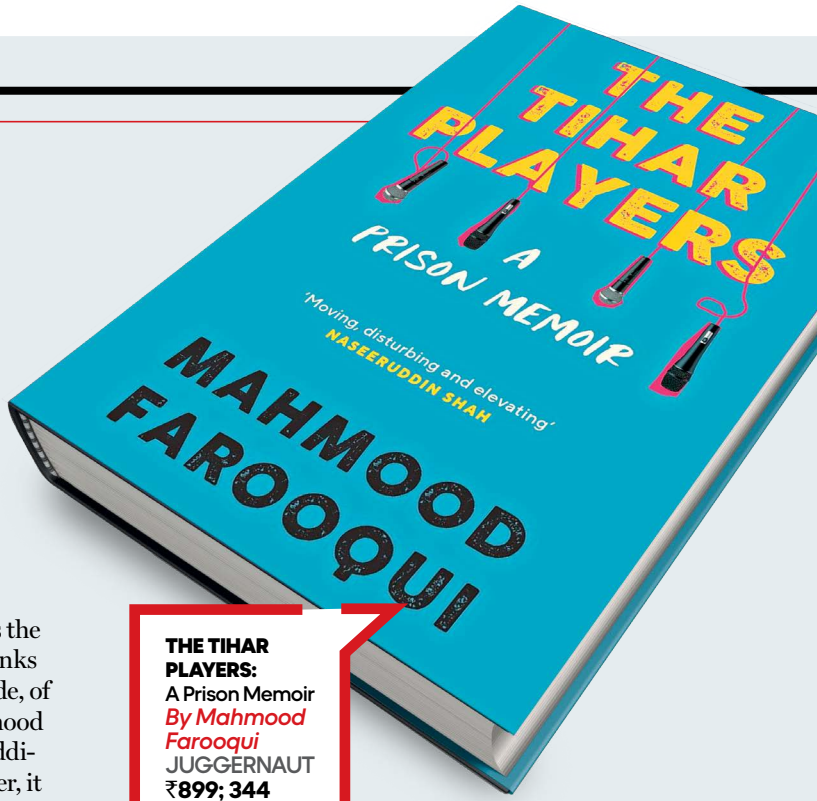
BOOKS ▼

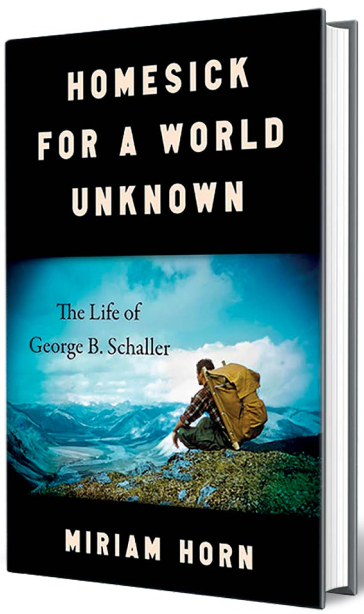
THEATRE BEHIND BARS

Mahmood Farooqui's The Tihar Players is a moving meditation on practising theatre in an unlikely setting



THE TIHAR PLAYERS:
A Prison Memoir
By Mahmood Farooqui
JUGGERNAUT
₹899; 344 pages

The prison memoir has emerged as perhaps the key literary genre of this moment. One thinks of Sudha Bharadwaj and Anand Teltumbde, of Kobad Ghandy and Arun Ferreira. Mahmood Farooqui's *The Tihar Players* is a fitting addition to this worthy and, alas, still growing list. However, it is worth stating upfront that Farooqui was not imprisoned for the honourable 'crimes' that attract incarceration in



HOMESICK FOR A WORLD UNKNOWN: THE LIFE OF GEORGE B. SCHALLER
By Miriam Horn
PENGUIN PRESS, 2026
₹3,233; 640 pages

BOOKS ▼

A LIFE LIVED WILD

MIRIAM HORN'S biography chronicles the life of a pioneering conservationist with sensitivity and formidable scholarship

Among my treasured possessions is a signed copy of a 1965 issue of *Life* magazine featuring a "rare close-up" of the tiger. Written by field biologist George Schaller, it draws on the year he spent observing tigers and their prey in Kanha National Park.

Schaller's pioneering work resulted in *The Deer and the Tiger*. This study of tigers was one of many firsts in an extraordinary life, vividly chronicled here by Miriam Horn. Following two chapters on Schaller's early years, Horn structures the book around the landscapes and species he studied across 32 countries: gorillas, tigers, lions, snow leopards, giant pandas and the wild sheep, antelopes and bears of Central Asia.

> The larger lesson of Schaller's is to put the subject **before the scientist** and to serve the lands and species studied

Horn recounts this immense life with lyricism and formidable scholarship. She read over 20,000 pages of Schaller's field journals, interviewed family and colleagues, and made two journeys into the field with him—including to Kanha, where he had established the necessity of plentiful prey for stable tiger populations.

In Horn's rendering of the diversity of Schaller's work, his biography becomes a history of modern conservation. From postcolonial upheaval in the Congo and China's Cultural Revolution to wars, political decisions and convulsions determine whether landscapes—and the animals within them—survive.